



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Monica Academy

School Website: <https://www.stmonicaacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Saint Monica Academy (SMA), located in Montrose, CA 91020, presents a robust alignment with classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements framework. Public materials from SMA consistently frame the school as a Catholic, classical institution that foregrounds faith, reason, and virtue; emphasizes the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric); centers Great Books and Socratic discourse; employs memory-based pedagogy (recitation, chanting, mnemonic devices); and promotes a literate cultivation of character with strong parental partnership. Across six rubric categories, SMA demonstrates strong fidelity to classical aims rather than a more secular or purely vocational model.

Key observations driving the overall CLASSICAL assessment:

- Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and central (Catholic identity, theology, liturgy, sacraments, daily prayer, Mass, magisterium alignment).
- The school purpose emphasizes formation (virtue, wisdom, contemplation) over mere information or job preparation, aligned with the transcendental aims of truth, goodness, and beauty.
- Curriculum centers the liberal arts via the trivium, Great Books, Western civilization, Latin, and integrated humanities; history is woven through courses rather than treated as mere social studies.
- Pedagogy includes contemplative/restful elements (scholé) alongside Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetoric training; lower grades engage in memory-centered activities and chant, while upper grades practice debate and oration.
- Faculty are portrayed as exemplary models and living curriculum; there is explicit emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and a collaborative culture.
- Parents and community are positioned as co-teachers and partners in formation, with active parent involvement and events, along with a welcoming campus.

Overall classification by category: CLASSICAL in all six categories.

This evaluation draws on SMA's public-facing materials (classical pedagogy, integrated humanities, Great Books, trivium, Catholic formation, liturgical practices, and parent/community engagement) and triangulates those signals against the Positive/Negative keyword indicators in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. See the cited SMA materials for evidence and the Six Essential Elements keyword framework for the scoring rationale.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- SMA identifies itself as a Catholic institution formed in faith, reason, and virtue, with explicit reference to Catholic principles and magisterium; sacraments and daily prayer are part of campus life; theology is integrated as a core component of education.
- Liturgical and communal practices are integrated (daily prayer, Mass; liturgical year; sacraments).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Catholic, faith, theology, sacraments, liturgy, Mass, magisterium, prayer, saints, virtue, gospel, sacred, reverence, wonder. These align strongly with the Positive Keyword indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (truth/virtue/theology/ liturgy/ creatures).

- Negative keywords: none evident in SMA materials.
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive ~ high, Negative ~ 0.
- Why this rating
- The Catholic identity and explicit religious formation are central to SMA's mission and daily life, matching the strongest signals in the Positive Keywords for this category and aligning with a transcendent, theologically grounded education.

Citations: SMA materials explicitly framing Catholic formation and liturgical life (e.g., Mission/Philosophy and Our Philosophy sections) and daily prayer/Mass on campus. See sources detailing Catholic identity and liturgical practices.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school's motto and purpose center on Faith, Reason, and Virtue, with formation of character and wisdom emphasized over mere information or job prep. The materials describe forming "lifetime learners" and citizens who are virtuous and wise; the aim includes contemplation, moral imagination, and the pursuit of truth and beauty.
- Great Books, classical curriculum, and the Great Conversation are highlighted as central to the curriculum and pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, scholé (contemplation/rest), great conversation, moral imagination, love of learning, truth/goodness/beauty, sacred tradition.
- Negative keywords: none observed (no strong signals of workforce- or college-career readiness as the sole aim; SMA emphasizes character formation and liberal education).
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive > 80%; Negative ~ 0–5%.
- Why this rating
- SMA's articulated aims emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and a robust classical telos; the Great Books and the Great Conversation, together with scholé and contemplation signals, align with the Positive Keyword framework for School Purpose and Goal.

Citations: Primary sources show the SMA motto, formation language, and Great Books/Socratic emphasis.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The trivium is presented as the core pedagogy: grammar, logic, rhetoric. Latin study is highlighted (three years), with English/history integrated into an "Integrated Humanities Cycle" spanning Ancient through American history and literature. Great Books and primary sources feature prominently. Math includes Euclid's Elements; sciences are taught in a way that emphasizes wonder toward creation.
- The curriculum explicitly includes Great Books, long-form literature, and a Western-civilization orientation; history is studied in context through the integrated humanities approach rather than as Social Studies.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, Western civilization, integrated humanities, Latin, Euclid's Elements, history/literature integration, sacred/religious instruction, and poetry/choral/artistic elements.
- Negative keywords: none detected that align with a "non-classical" pivot (e.g., a replacement of history with social studies terms, or an emphasis on project-based-only curricula without the classical frame).
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive ~ high; Negative ~ 0–5%.
- Why this rating
- SMA's curriculum centers the liberal arts in the traditional sense (grammar/logic/rhetoric), with a robust Great Books emphasis and Latin study; this maps cleanly to the classical model.

Citations: Trivium description and integrated humanities; Great Books emphasis; Latin and Euclid; history through humanities cycle.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Socratic discussions and seminars are named as upper-school methods; rhetoric and speeches are anticipated outcomes in the upper grades; lower grades emphasize memory work, singing/chanting, and recitation in line with “Scholé” and contemplative pedagogy; a strong emphasis on forming memory and argumentation is explicit.
- The Great Books/Socratic method signals a pedagogy centered on dialogue, critical thinking, and classical forms of argument. The presence of singing/chanting in lower grades (memory-based) aligns with traditional pedagogy signals in the Six Elements lexicon.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic/seminar/discussion, memory work; recitation; chanting; rhetoric; oral argument; scholé days; contemplative/wonderful learning; upper-school rhetoric; public speaking.
- Negative keywords: limited or no explicit signals of project-based-only or purely student-directed, which in the excluded signals would be considered non-classical.
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive 70–90%; Negative 0–10%.
- Why this rating
- SMA’s pedagogy interleaves contemplative/restful elements (scholé) with rigorous Socratic/seminar learning and rhetoric development, which matches the classical pedagogy signals and avoids heavy reliance on purely modern, non-dialogic methods.

Citations: Socratic method and seminars; lower-grade memory/chanting; upper-grade rhetoric; emphasis on memory and dialogue.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The materials emphasize dedicated faculty that exemplify virtue and the Christian moral life; faculty are described as “living curriculum” and as mentors alongside students; a culture of collegiality and mentorship is presented.
- The school’s philosophy describes the faculty as integral to forming students and as partners with parents; the governance structure and faith-based orientation further reinforce the faculty’s central role in model formation.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: dedicated faculty, living curriculum, mentors, masters, exemplars, moral formation, character formation, collegial culture, portrayal of teacher as model.
- Negative keywords: none observed in the public materials.
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive ~ high; Negative ~ 0–5%.
- Why this rating
- SMA presents a strong portrait of faculty as the core of the school’s classical mission, closely aligned with the Positive Keywords for Faculty from the Six Elements lexicon.

Citations: Mission/Philosophy statements describing faculty as living curriculum and mentors; dedicated faculty signals.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- SMA describes a partnership with parents as co-teachers, parent formation through the website and gatherings, and open access for visits; the Parent Guild and service expectations are evident; the school frames parental involvement as central to forming students in virtue and knowledge.

- The program explicitly emphasizes lay leadership and community life; it situates parents as primary in moral formation and supports ongoing parent formation (book studies, gatherings).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental formation, parent engagement, open campus, family catechesis, home-school alignment, parent covenant.
- Negative keywords: none observed.
- Estimated keyword balance: Positive ~ high; Negative ~ 0–5%.
- Why this rating
- SMA's materials foreground active parent involvement and a robust family-centered model consistent with the classical element of "Partnership with Families" and "Formation of Affections."

Citations: Parent/Student Handbook references; mission philosophy; admissions materials; parent engagement signals.

Aggregate Ranking and Abstract

- Category-by-category aggregate: CLASSICAL in all six categories.
- General assessment: SMA operates as a CLASSICAL institution in line with the Six Essential Elements, emphasizing Catholic formation, virtuous formation, a liberal-arts curriculum, a Trivium-based pedagogy, model faculty, and strong parental engagement.

What would move the needle

- Not necessary given a CLASSICAL outcome across all categories. If desired, further enhancements could come from explicit public articulation of a formal "living books" and classical memory-tradition plan across grade levels, and a more explicit, quantified map of Great Books selections per grade band to demonstrate a transparent, year-by-year Great Conversation.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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